# Barking up the tree

*The green inner bark* turns blue, purple, and orange when exposed to the air.

*The red-brown bark* can be up to 11 in (30 cm) thick.

**Fibrous**
(Coast redwood)

*The bright green bark with white stripes* is easily damaged in strong sunlight.

**Vertical stripes**
(Manchurian striped maple)

**Spiny**
(Silk floss)

*Cone-shaped spines* protect this greenish gray bark against animals.

*Unusual rectangular plates* make it easy to identify a persimmon tree's bark.

**Plates**
(Persimmon)

*This smooth gray bark* can be infected by deadly fungi.

**Smooth**
(American beech)

**Bark is the woody "skin" that protects the trunks of trees and stems of shrubs, forming a barrier against disease and grazing animals, while keeping water in. Bark is essentially dead tissue—a tough layer formed as the living cells underneath it die and are replaced.**

Tree bark comes in many different patterns and textures and is vital to the health of a tree. The fibrous bark of the **coast redwood** is extremely fire-resistant, while the spines on **silk floss** bark deter any hungry animals from eating the young branches. Since all trunks need air to